

CROSS-BRAND PATTERN REPORT

What five successful supplement brands have in common

Cross-brand patterns: MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, Vida Glow, SmartyPants

Supplements, wellness and nutricosmetics. Home markets: US, UK, Australia. Lens: what successful brands share, where they differ, and the warning signs.

Run date: 6 October 2026 | Analyst: brand-pattern-finder | Design: report-designer

How to read the confidence tags

Patterns are rated MEDIUM (several brands support it) or EARLY SIGNAL (one or two brands). No pattern is rated higher than medium because the evidence is snippet-based and the set has no failed brands. Dated facts carry the brand reports' tags: CONFIRMED (brand or investor statement, solid data), REPORTED (credible third party), INFERRED (analyst reasoning), USER-SUPPLIED (from the user; none in this set).

Contents

1. Key findings.....	3
2. Summary and caveats.....	4
Caveats that apply to everything in this report.....	4
3. Scorecard.....	5
4. How the five brands compare.....	6
Story, hero product and price.....	6
Marketing and sales channels.....	6
Success measures.....	7
5. What the successful brands share.....	8
P1. Founder's personal problem is the origin story.....	9
P2. Format or hero makes the promise visible at a glance.....	9
P3. Demand proven online before physical retail.....	9
P4. Amazon was an early growth engine.....	10
P5. Creators and social commerce drive sales.....	10
P6. Women buy; ranges follow life stages.....	10
P7. Beauty-from-within is a growth extension.....	10
P8. A trust stack stands in for clinical trials.....	10
P9. Founder-controlled, capital-light growth.....	11
6. Different routes to the same result.....	12
P10. Deep home market vs early internationalisation.....	12
P11. Retail destination differs: mass/club, pharmacy or prestige beauty.....	13
P12. Success by exit vs founder-retained scale.....	13
7. Warning signs: where story and product or channel pulled apart.....	14
W1. Range sprawl into trend SKUs.....	14
W2. Claims escalate beyond the evidence.....	14
W3. 'Premium' story vs deep discounting.....	14
W4. 'Global' story vs unmanaged international.....	14
8. Distinct success models.....	15
Alternative explanations.....	15
9. Implications for a new brand or product launch.....	16
10. Open questions and gaps.....	17
Evidence quality.....	17
Failed or stalled brands to add (the set has none).....	17
Recommended Spate category searches.....	17
11. Sources.....	19

1. Key findings

Five successful brands share a founder story, an online-first path and a format that shows the promise; they also share the same two warning signs. All of it is medium-confidence correlation.

5 of 5

brands with a founder-problem origin story

All five brands began with a founder's personal problem and proved demand online before physical retail. [MEDIUM]

Pill aversion (MaryRuth's), a family health scare (Free Soul), unfinished vitamin tubs (Novomins), hair loss (Vida Glow) and a child who would not take vitamins (SmartyPants). Story clarity scores 4-5 for every brand, the highest-scoring criterion. Four brands built reviews, velocity or virality online first and used it to win retail; the gap between launch and major retail was 2-7 years (P1, P3).

4 of 5

brands where the format itself proves the story

The clearest shared lever is a format or hero that makes the promise visible at a glance. [MEDIUM]

Liquid for 'no pills' (MaryRuth's), gummy for 'kids will take it' and 'easy to remember' (SmartyPants, Novomins), a single 100%-collagen sachet (Vida Glow). It works in a 15-second video, an Amazon thumbnail or a shelf facing without explanation. Free Soul is the exception: it differentiates by audience (women-first), though it still needed a viral hero, Mango Greens (17m+ servings), to break out (P2).

3 routes

two of them rest on one brand each

Three routes reach success: a mass engine, a pharmacy shelf block and prestige beauty. [MEDIUM / EARLY SIGNAL]

Marketplace-and-creator mass engine: MaryRuth's, Free Soul, earlier SmartyPants (medium, 3 brands). Pharmacy-shelf need-state block: Novomins (early signal, 1 brand). Prestige-beauty placement with celebrity launches: Vida Glow (early signal, 1 brand). SmartyPants also shows a fourth outcome, a strategic exit to Unilever (early signal).

5 of 5

brands with trend-SKU sprawl and claims escalation

The same warning signs appear in all five: range sprawl and claims that run ahead of evidence. [MEDIUM (COMMON) / EARLY SIGNAL (HARM)]

Story-product fit is the lowest or joint-lowest score for four of the five brands. SmartyPants already faces two class actions aimed at its core promise (2021 'Complete', 2025 fiber). For the other brands no ASA, FTC or court action was found; the risk is mainly that these claims block or reshape EU/UK entry (W1, W2).

0

failed or stalled brands in the set

Treat every pattern as a medium-confidence correlation, not a proven cause. [CAVEAT]

Evidence comes from search-result snippets, and some success figures are self-reported or estimated. Timing (TikTok Shop, the gummy boom), category growth, funding and founder networks explain part of the results. Adding failed brands and Spate category data would test the patterns.

2. Summary and caveats

The shared path is founder problem, visible format, online proof, then retail; three different retail destinations then lead to success.

All five brands started with a founder's personal problem, proved demand online (own site and/or Amazon) before entering physical retail, and sell mainly to women buying for themselves or their families. Within that, the clearest shared lever is a product format or hero that makes the founding promise visible at a glance (liquid, gummy, sachet, mango greens), which then suits the brand's lead channel, whether that is TikTok, Amazon thumbnails or a pharmacy or beauty shelf. Three routes reach success: a marketplace-and-creator mass engine (MaryRuth's, Free Soul, earlier SmartyPants), a pharmacy-shelf need-state block (Novomins) and prestige-beauty placement backed by celebrity launches (Vida Glow), with the last two each resting on one brand only. The same warning signs appear in all five: range sprawl into trend SKUs and claims that run ahead of evidence, which has already produced lawsuits at SmartyPants and is the main EU/UK exposure for the others. Because the evidence is snippet-based and the set has no failures, these are medium-confidence correlations; timing (TikTok Shop, the gummy boom), category growth and founder audiences explain part of the result.

Caveats that apply to everything in this report

Evidence caveat [CAVEAT]

All five brand reports were built from search-result snippets, because the network blocked direct page fetches (brand sites, Forbes, Lloyds, The Grocer, founder interviews and others). Exact figures, dates and wording have not been checked against full pages. Several success figures are self-reported (Vida Glow units, Novomins velocity, Free Soul revenue) or third-party estimates (MaryRuth's revenue from Forbes, SmartyPants revenue from databases). For this reason no pattern is rated higher than medium, even where all five brands support it.

Survivorship caveat [CAVEAT]

All five brands are successes by their own measure. With no failed or stalled brands in the set, every shared trait is a correlation, not a proven cause.

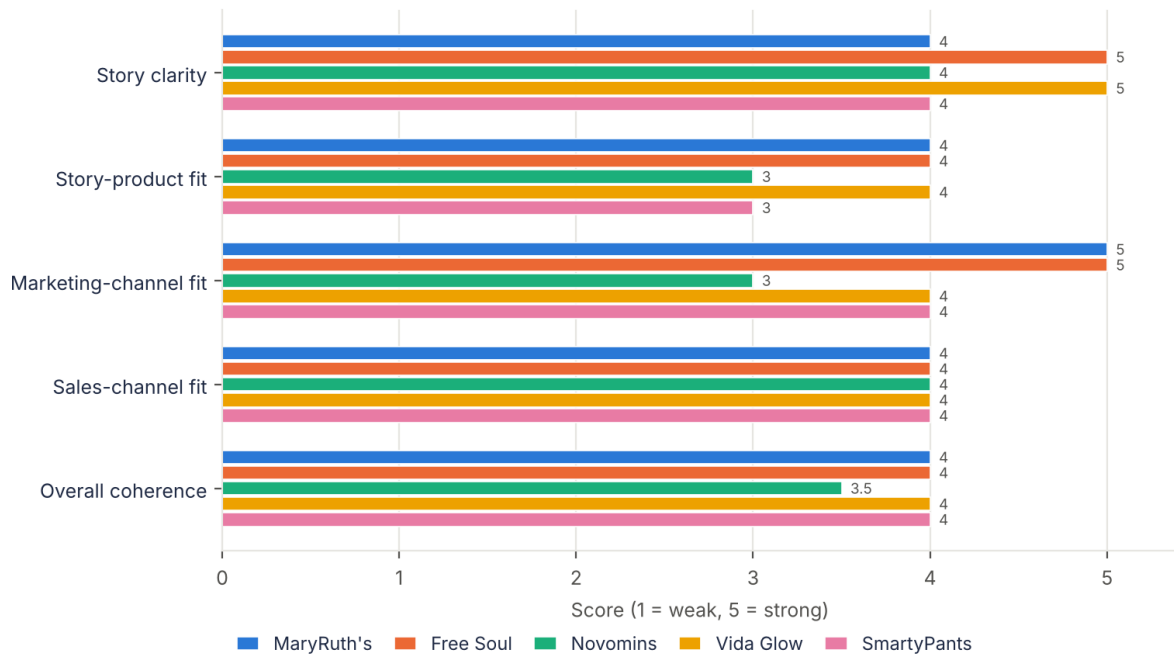
Brands compared (5): MaryRuth's (US), Free Soul (UK), Novomins (UK), Vida Glow (Australia), SmartyPants (US). No Spate export was available in inputs/category/ and Revuze was not used.

3. Scorecard

Every brand scores 4-5 on story clarity, while story-product fit is the lowest or joint-lowest score for four of the five.

Story clarity scores highest; story-product fit scores lowest

Average across brands: clarity 4.4, marketing 4.2, sales 4.0, overall 3.9, story-product 3.6



Source: brand reports' scorecards, 2026-10-06 (1-5 scale); same scores in the pattern report's comparison matrix

Figure 1: Brand scorecards on five criteria (1-5). Source: brand reports, 2026-10-06.

Table 1: Scorecard as a heat-map table (darker = higher). Novomins' overall score is 3.5.

Brand	Story clarity	Story-product fit	Marketing-channel fit	Sales-channel fit	Overall coherence
MaryRuth's	4	4	5	4	4
Free Soul	5	4	5	4	4
Novomins	4	3	3	4	3.5
Vida Glow	5	4	4	4	4
SmartyPants	4	3	4	4	4

Reading the scores: story clarity is the highest-scoring criterion in the set (P1). Story-product fit is pulled down by range sprawl into trend SKUs (W1). Novomins scores 3 on marketing-channel fit because little social or creator activity was found, which the report treats as a gap rather than evidence of absence.

4. How the five brands compare

All five tell a founder-problem story, but their hero formats, price tiers and success measures differ widely.

Story, hero product and price

Table 2: Story type, hero product and price tier. Source: pattern report comparison matrix.

Brand	Story type	Hero product and format	Price tier
MaryRuth's (US, 2014)	Founder-problem: health coach whose clients could not take pills ("liquids until lunch"); family, clean, mother-founded	Liquid Morning Multivitamin (sugar-free liquid); 2025 growth hero Liquid Multivitamin + Hair Growth (Lustriva, biotin)	Mid-premium mass (about \$31-54 per bottle; deep Amazon deals)
Free Soul (UK, 2017)	Founder-problem: mother and son after a family health scare; "female-first nutrition", how women feel, not how they look	Started with women's protein powders; viral hero Mango Greens powder (17m+ servings), 7-sachet retail packs	Masstige (about £15 multi, about £30 greens)
Novomins (UK, 2020)	Founder-problem: clinician founders (dentist, pharmacologist) saw unfinished, expired vitamin tubs; "make the healthy choice the obvious choice"	Gummy-only range (40+ SKUs); heroes Women's Bio-Balance, Collagen, Magnesium	Mass-premium (£19.99 per 60)
Vida Glow (Australia, 2014)	Founder-problem plus discovery: founder's hair loss, fixed with marine collagen found in Japan	Natural Marine Collagen 3g sachets (powder); later Pro Collagen+, Collagen Liquid Advance	Prestige beauty (US\$50 per 30 sachets)
SmartyPants (US, 2010-11)	Founder-problem: parent founders could not find a vitamin that was premium, tasty and affordable; "all-in-one"	Kids multi + omega-3 + D3 gummy; later life-stage, organic, sugar-free gummies	Masstige list price, often value-tier paid price (Amazon deals)

Marketing and sales channels

Table 3: Lead marketing channel, first sales channel and channel expansion sequence. Source: pattern report.

Brand	Lead marketing channel	First sales channel	Channel expansion sequence
MaryRuth's (US, 2014)	Always-on creator programme (1,000+ creators) plus TikTok Shop 24/7 LIVE and Amazon ads	Founder's coaching practice and Amazon (2014-15)	Coaching practice > Amazon > DTC > US natural and mass retail from 2021 (Whole Foods, 800+ Target, Walmart, Costco, Ulta, CVS) > TikTok Shop from 2024; EU/UK grey-market only
Free Soul (UK, 2017)	TikTok organic, LIVE and TikTok Shop (first UK brand with two Super Brand Days, Oct 2024 and Jan 2026)	DTC Shopify with subscription, seeded by gym sampling	DTC > Amazon UK > TikTok Shop (by 2024) > UK mass retail 2024-25 (H&B, Boots, Tesco, Superdrug, Sainsbury's, Waitrose, Ocado) > Ireland; No US
Novomins (UK, 2020)	Trade and business press, reviews (Trustpilot 4.8, Amazon 5.0); social/creator activity not found	DTC and Amazon UK (2020)	DTC / Amazon > Chemist Warehouse Ireland (Nov 2022) > UK Boots, Superdrug, H&B (about 20,000 points claimed) > Chemist Warehouse Australia (550 stores, c. 2025) > DE/AT online; US thin
Vida Glow (Australia, 2014)	Celebrity launch events per market, founder Instagram, glossy beauty press	DTC Australia (2014)	DTC > AU health-food wholesale > China demand (2017) > 2021 global rebrand > US prestige (Revolve, Neiman Marcus, 2022) > UK prestige (Harrods, Space NK, Cult Beauty, Sephora UK) > Sephora AU; EU light

Brand	Lead marketing channel	First sales channel	Channel expansion sequence
SmartyPants (US, 2010-11)	Amazon reviews and search ranking; mom influencers; Vitamin Angels 1-for-1 cause	DTC and Amazon (2010-11)	DTC / Amazon > Natural (Whole Foods, Sprouts) > Mass and club (30,000+ doors by 2018: Target, Walmart, Costco) > Unilever (2020) > Walmart-specific line (2023); No EU/UK

Success measures

Success is measured differently for each brand, so the figures cannot be ranked against each other.

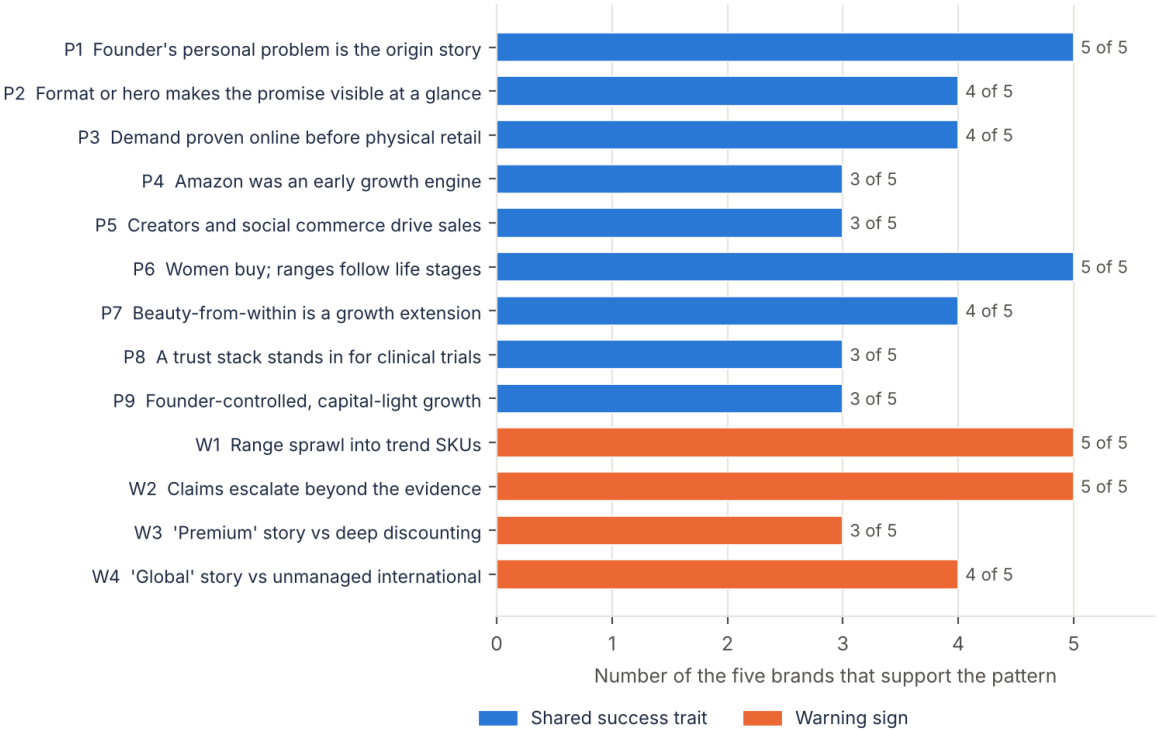
Table 4: Success measure per brand, with the evidence tag from the brand report.

Brand	Success measure	Evidence
MaryRuth's (US, 2014)	Scale, profit and founder control: about \$600M TTM revenue, about \$125M EBITDA, at least \$1.5B equity value (Forbes estimate, Aug 2026); family owns about 97%	REPORTED (estimate)
Free Soul (UK, 2017)	Founder-retained revenue growth: £35-42m (2025 to year to Apr 2026), Sunday Times 100 #10, reported EBITDA positive; one angel round	REPORTED
Novomins (UK, 2020)	Bootstrapped growth (£70k savings, Lloyds debt): £3.5m in about 2 years (company figure), Sunday Times 100 #27 (Jun 2026); current revenue not found	REPORTED
Vida Glow (Australia, 2014)	Units and footprint, mostly self-reported ("one unit every four seconds", "world's No.1 marine collagen brand"); revenue, funding, ownership not found	Self-reported
SmartyPants (US, 2010-11)	Exit: acquired by Unilever (Nov-Dec 2020, terms undisclosed); revenue estimates conflict (\$52M 2017; "over \$100M" pre-exit)	CONFIRMED (exit) / REPORTED (revenue)

5. What the successful brands share

Two traits (founder-problem origin, women as buyer) appear in all five brands; four more appear in four; none is rated above medium confidence.

Two success traits and two warning signs appear in all five brands



Source: Cross-brand pattern report, 2026-10-06 (brand-pattern-finder). Count = brands the report lists as supporting each pattern
Figure 2: Number of brands supporting each pattern. Source: pattern report, 2026-10-06.

MaryRuth's matches all 13 patterns; Vida Glow is the most frequent exception

	MaryRuth's	Free Soul	Novomins	Vida Glow	SmartyPants
P1 Founder's personal problem is the origin story	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
P2 Format or hero makes the promise visible at a glance	Yes	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
P3 Demand proven online before physical retail	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes
P4 Amazon was an early growth engine	Yes	?	Yes	No	Yes
P5 Creators and social commerce drive sales	Yes	Yes	?	No	Yes
P6 Women buy; ranges follow life stages	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
P7 Beauty-from-within is a growth extension	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No
P8 A trust stack stands in for clinical trials	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
P9 Founder-controlled, capital-light growth	Yes	Yes	Yes	?	No
W1 Range sprawl into trend SKUs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
W2 Claims escalate beyond the evidence	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
W3 'Premium' story vs deep discounting	Yes	No	Yes	No	Yes
W4 'Global' story vs unmanaged international	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	Yes

■ Yes: brand supports the pattern
 ■ No: named exception
 ■ ?: not found or unconfirmed

Source: Cross-brand pattern report, 2026-10-06 (brand-pattern-finder). Rows P1-P9 = shared traits, W1-W4 = warning signs

Figure 3: Pattern-by-brand matrix: which brands support each pattern, which are named exceptions, and where evidence was not found. Source: pattern report, 2026-10-06.

P1. Founder's personal problem is the origin story

Confidence: [MEDIUM]

Every brand opens with a first-person problem, and the story stays the same for years. Story-clarity scores are 4-5 for all five, the highest-scoring criterion in the set.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, Vida Glow, SmartyPants (5)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** None in the set. But this is near-universal in the category, including in brands that fail, so it is probably necessary rather than distinctive.

P2. Format or hero makes the promise visible at a glance

Confidence: [MEDIUM]

The product itself is the proof of the story, so it can be shown in a 15-second video, an Amazon thumbnail or a shelf facing without explanation.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Novomins, Vida Glow, SmartyPants (4)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** Free Soul differentiates by audience (women-first), not by format; Mango Greens is a flavour and positioning win within an existing format. Partial: Novomins has no single hero, it has a format applied to a 40+ SKU range.

P3. Demand proven online before physical retail

Confidence: [MEDIUM]

Each brand built evidence of demand (reviews, sales velocity, social virality) online, then used it to win retail listings. The gap between launch and major retail was 2-7 years.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, SmartyPants (4)

- **Exceptions and caveats:** Vida Glow moved into Australian health-food wholesale within two years of launch; its prestige retail push (2021-22) did follow years of DTC and China demand. Alternative explanation: this is the standard route for any small brand without retail funding.

P4. Amazon was an early growth engine

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

Amazon was a primary channel from the start; reviews and search rank served as both a sales channel and proof for retail buyers.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Novomins, SmartyPants (3)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** Vida Glow (Amazon presence unclear, may be a reseller). Free Soul has a 'strong Amazon channel' but its start date is not found. Weakened by heavy Amazon discounting at MaryRuth's and SmartyPants: rank may partly be bought.

P5. Creators and social commerce drive sales

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

The founder's voice is multiplied by creators who resemble the founder or buyer; in the two newest cases sales happen on the same platform (TikTok Shop). MaryRuth's was the #4 TikTok Shop seller in Jan 2025 with 1,000+ creators; Free Soul held two Super Brand Days; SmartyPants ran a mom-influencer programme (26M+ reach).

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, SmartyPants (3)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** Novomins: no social or creator evidence found (a gap, not evidence of absence). Vida Glow uses celebrities and founder Instagram instead. Timing explains part: TikTok Shop opened in the UK in 2021 and the US in late 2023.

P6. Women buy; ranges follow life stages

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

Every brand sells mainly to women, for themselves or for their families. Need-state naming maps onto how retail fixtures are organised.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, Vida Glow, SmartyPants (5)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** None, though SmartyPants and MaryRuth's address the mother as buyer for the family. Women are the majority supplement buyer, so this is close to a category trait.

P7. Beauty-from-within is a growth extension

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

Four brands started in or moved into hair, skin and collagen; in two cases that extension became a top seller (MaryRuth's Hair Growth liquid was the #2 TikTok Shop product in Jan 2025; Novomins Collagen gummies are a stated bestseller).

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, Vida Glow (4)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** SmartyPants (no beauty line found). Beauty claims carry the highest claim risk (see W2).

P8. A trust stack stands in for clinical trials

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

None of the five has a published clinical trial on a finished product. Trust comes from certifications (B Corp, Clean Label Project, Vegan Society), contaminant testing, cause programmes, clinician founders or ingredient-supplier studies.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Novomins, SmartyPants (3)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** Free Soul (Informed Sport page exists, SKUs unconfirmed; relies on customer surveys); Vida Glow (no certifications found; relies on brand-run, unpublished studies and celebrity).

P9. Founder-controlled, capital-light growth

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

Brands grew on founder money, an angel or debt rather than venture equity: MaryRuth's bootstrapped to about \$100M, took PE in 2021 and bought it back with debt in 2024; Free Soul self-funded with one angel round; Novomins used £70k savings plus Lloyds debt.

- **Supporting:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins (3)
- **Exceptions and caveats:** SmartyPants (crowdfunding, then PE, then sale to Unilever). Vida Glow (funding not found). Profitable founders talk about bootstrapping more, so the trait may be over-reported among winners.

6. Different routes to the same result

The online-first start is shared, but the retail destination, the geography and the ownership outcome differ by brand.

Major retail came years after the online launch for four of the five brands

Vida Glow is the exception: AU health-food wholesale began c. 2014-16, alongside DTC



Source: timeline tables in the five brand reports, 2026-10-06; dates as reported (several approximate).
Labels: online launch (above the line), first dated retail milestone in the brand report (below).

Figure 4: Dated milestones per brand (online launch, physical retail, social commerce, funding, other). Source: brand-report timelines, 2026-10-06.

Table 5: Sales-channel presence as listed in the pattern report. First = first sales channel; - = not listed (not proof of absence); No = stated as absent or unofficial.

Brand	DTC site	Amazon	TikTok Shop	Natural / health store	Mass, grocery, club	Pharmacy	Prestige beauty	Official international
MaryRuth's	Yes	First	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	-	No
Free Soul	First	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	-	Yes
Novomins	First	First	-	Yes	-	Yes	-	Yes
Vida Glow	First	-	-	Yes	-	-	Yes	Yes
SmartyPants	First	First	-	Yes	Yes	-	-	No

- **MaryRuth's:** Started in the founder's coaching practice and on Amazon; CVS for pharmacy; EU/UK grey-market only.
- **Free Soul:** H&B (health store), Boots and Superdrug (pharmacy), Tesco, Sainsbury's, Waitrose, Ocado (grocery); international = Ireland; no US.
- **Novomins:** H&B (health store); Boots, Superdrug and Chemist Warehouse (pharmacy); international = Ireland, Australia, DE/AT online; US thin.
- **Vida Glow:** AU health-food wholesale; Revolve, Neiman Marcus, Harrods, Space NK, Cult Beauty, Sephora; official in AU, US, UK; EU light. Amazon presence unclear.
- **SmartyPants:** Whole Foods and Sprouts (natural); Target, Walmart, Costco (30,000+ doors by 2018); no EU/UK.

P10. Deep home market vs early internationalisation

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM \(HOME MARKET\) / EARLY SIGNAL \(INTERNATIONAL\)\]](#)

Three brands scaled almost entirely in one home market and left international sales unmanaged: MaryRuth's (US), SmartyPants (US), Free Soul (UK plus Ireland). Two expanded early through a specific partner or demand

pocket: Novomins (Ireland, Australia, Germany via Chemist Warehouse and online pharmacy), Vida Glow (China demand, then US and UK prestige).

P11. Retail destination differs: mass/club, pharmacy or prestige beauty

Confidence: [MEDIUM (MASS) / EARLY SIGNAL (PHARMACY, PRESTIGE)]

The online-first start is shared, but the retail destination matches price tier and story: mass and club for a family staple (MaryRuth's, SmartyPants, Free Soul's grocery listings), pharmacy and health-store fixtures for a need-state gummy block (Novomins), prestige beauty for a US\$50 sachet sold as beauty (Vida Glow).

P12. Success by exit vs founder-retained scale

Confidence: [EARLY SIGNAL (EXIT ROUTE)]

SmartyPants succeeded by selling to a strategic buyer; MaryRuth's, Free Soul and Novomins by growing while keeping control. Vida Glow is unknown.

7. Warning signs: where story and product or channel pulled apart

Range sprawl and claims escalation appear in all five brands; only SmartyPants has faced legal action so far.

W1. Range sprawl into trend SKUs

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM \(COMMON\) / EARLY SIGNAL \(HARM\)\]](#)

300+ SKUs vs 'make wellness simple' (MaryRuth's); Sculpt and 'glow' vs 'how women feel, not how they look' (Free Soul); NAD+, shilajit and libido vs 'established science' (Novomins); acne, sleep, topicals and a tea collaboration vs 'the marine collagen brand' (Vida Glow); sleep, fiber and pet SKUs vs 'all-in-one' (SmartyPants).

- **Brands affected:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, Vida Glow, SmartyPants (5)
- **What followed / exceptions:** No commercial damage documented yet for any brand. At SmartyPants, sprawl coincides with a post-acquisition period in which it is not named among Unilever's growth leaders (weak signal).

W2. Claims escalate beyond the evidence

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM \(COMMON\) / EARLY SIGNAL \(CONSEQUENCES\)\]](#)

'Clinically shown' hair growth on an ingredient-supplier study plus 10,000 mcg biotin (MaryRuth's); survey percentages and 'hormone balance' (Free Soul); disease-adjacent naming such as 'Endo' (Novomins); 'clinically proven' and 'world's No.1' without published data (Vida Glow); 'Complete' and fiber claims (SmartyPants).

- **Brands affected:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, Vida Glow, SmartyPants (5)
- **What followed / exceptions:** SmartyPants faces two class actions (2021 'Complete', 2025 fiber). MaryRuth's had a 2021 infant probiotic recall (safety, not claims). For the other three, no ASA, FTC or court action was found.

W3. 'Premium' story vs deep discounting

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM \(OCCURS\) / EFFECT NOT SHOWN\]](#)

List prices say premium while the price paid is often value-tier: MaryRuth's (50% off list on Amazon), SmartyPants (120 ct for \$5-9 with coupons), Novomins (H&B 15-20% multibuy).

- **Brands affected:** MaryRuth's, Novomins, SmartyPants (3)
- **What followed / exceptions:** Vida Glow (only 15% subscription discount found); Free Soul (25% first-order affiliate offers, not persistent). No measured effect on margin; MaryRuth's still reports about 20% EBITDA (Forbes estimate).

W4. 'Global' story vs unmanaged international

Confidence: [\[MEDIUM\]](#)

MaryRuth's (grey-market EU/UK), Free Soul ('4 million women globally', no US), Novomins (US push announced c. 2022, by 2026 only a third-party Amazon listing), SmartyPants (no EU/UK under Unilever).

- **Brands affected:** MaryRuth's, Free Soul, Novomins, SmartyPants (4)
- **What followed / exceptions:** Vida Glow (official presence in AU, US, UK; EU light).

8. Distinct success models

Four models explain the five successes; only the mass engine rests on more than one brand.

Table 6: Success models, the brands that fit and confidence. Source: pattern report.

Model	How it works	Brands that fit	Confidence
Marketplace-and-creator mass engine	Visibly different format or positioning, proven on Amazon and/or DTC, scaled through creators and social commerce, then turned into mass, grocery and club listings.	MaryRuth's (US), Free Soul (UK), SmartyPants (US, pre-TikTok version with Amazon and mom influencers)	Medium (3 brands)
Pharmacy-shelf need-state block	One format (gummy) across many need-state SKUs at one price point, giving retailers a ready-made fixture block; clinician founders and B Corp reassure pharmacy buyers; growth funded by debt and retail partners across countries.	Novomins (partly SmartyPants in its life-stage mass listings)	Early signal (1 brand)
Prestige-beauty placement	Supplement sold as beauty: single-ingredient hero, giftable sachets, celebrity launch per market, beauty-retail doors at prestige prices.	Vida Glow	Early signal (1 brand)
Strategic exit	Staged capital (crowdfund, PE, growth equity) matched to staged channels, building a scaled US asset for a strategic buyer.	SmartyPants	Early signal (1 brand)

Alternative explanations

Timing, category growth, funding, founder networks and uneven measurement each explain part of the result, so the patterns above are correlations, not proven causes.

- **Timing.** TikTok Shop launched in the UK (2021) and US (late 2023) with heavy platform support for early brands; MaryRuth's and Free Soul were early and visible. SmartyPants rode the 2010-2020 rise of gummies and clean label. Vida Glow launched in 2014 as ingestible collagen was emerging, and caught Chinese cross-border demand in 2017. Each brand's main channel or format was growing fast when it entered.
- **Category growth.** Gummy supplements grew 7.9% in 2025 (New Hope, US data, cited in the Novomins report); collagen, greens and women's health have been fast-growing need-states. Without Spate category data, brand share gain cannot be separated from category growth for any of the five.
- **Funding.** MaryRuth's took PE in 2021 at the point it entered mass retail; SmartyPants raised repeatedly before 30,000 doors; Novomins used Lloyds debt for international retail. Capital access, not strategy alone, may explain the speed of retail rollout.
- **Founder audience and networks.** MaryRuth's started with the founder's coaching clients; Vida Glow used the founders' celebrity and fashion network (Rita Ora, later a Typebea co-founder); Free Soul used diaspora and business press. These are hard to copy and could explain early traction as well as any strategy.
- **Measurement.** The success evidence is uneven: Forbes estimates (MaryRuth's), company-stated and press-ranked figures (Free Soul, Novomins), unverified unit claims (Vida Glow) and an undisclosed exit price (SmartyPants). Some 'successes' may be smaller than presented.

9. Implications for a new brand or product launch

A new launch should pick a self-explaining format, prove demand online, choose one retail destination and write claims for the strictest market from day one.

1. Choose a format or hero that proves the promise by itself. If the product needs a paragraph to explain why it is different, it will not travel on TikTok, Amazon or a retail shelf (P2). Free Soul shows the alternative is a sharp audience position, but it still needed a viral hero (Mango Greens) to break out.

2. Plan the online-proof-then-retail sequence on purpose. Collect reviews, velocity and repeat data in DTC and Amazon first, then take them to retail buyers (P3, P4). Design trial-size sachets or small packs for retail entry price points, as Free Soul and Vida Glow did (early signal).

3. Match the retail destination to price and story. Mass and club for a family staple, pharmacy for need-state blocks, prestige beauty for a beauty-priced ingestible (P11). Mixing them (Vida Glow at Harrods and at Nasty Gal) creates price and positioning tension.

4. Build the trust stack early. With no finished-product clinical trial, certifications, testing and clinician or educator voices did the reassuring for three brands (P8). For a nutricosmetics launch, a finished-product study would be a real differentiator, since none of the five has one.

5. Write claims for the strictest target market from day one. All five brands' growth claims would need rework under EFSA/GB rules (W2). A brand planning UK/EU sales should build heroes around authorised nutrient claims (e.g. biotin, zinc, vitamin C for skin, hair and collagen formation) rather than adapting US claims later.

6. Set rules for line extension. Every brand drifted into trend SKUs (W1). A simple test: does the new SKU make the founding promise more tangible, or does it borrow a trend? Beauty extensions worked commercially for four brands (P7) but carry the highest claim risk.

7. Treat social commerce as a time-limited window. Early entry to a new platform (TikTok Shop) gave outsized reach to two brands; that advantage shrinks as the platform fills. A new brand should look for the next under-served channel rather than assume the same result.

10. Open questions and gaps

Full-page evidence, channel revenue mix and failed comparison brands are the three gaps that would most change confidence in these patterns.

Evidence quality

- All five brand reports rest on search-result snippets because direct fetches were blocked. Rerunning brand-analyst with full page access (brand sites, Forbes, Lloyds, The Grocer, Sunday Times 100, Unilever releases) would let several patterns move from medium to high confidence. Priorities: Free Soul and Novomins revenue (Companies House, Sunday Times 100 entries), Vida Glow revenue and ownership (ASIC), SmartyPants post-2020 performance.
- Channel revenue mix (Amazon vs DTC vs retail vs TikTok Shop) was not found for any brand. This is the single biggest gap for P4 and P5.
- Novomins social and creator activity was not found; checking it would confirm or break P5.

Failed or stalled brands to add (the set has none)

These are candidates from general category knowledge, not from the brand reports; their status should be checked by a brand-analyst run before use.

- **Care/of:** US personalised vitamin packs, Bayer-owned; reported closed in 2024: DTC subscription model with no retail-first proof; a test of P3.
- **Sugarbear:** US influencer-led hair gummies: celebrity and influencer demand without a trust stack; a test of P5 and P8.
- **Goli Nutrition:** US ACV gummies, viral c. 2020, reported financial difficulties later: a format-led hero that rode a trend; a test of P2 and of the timing explanation.
- **SmartyPants after 2020:** Already in the set: a possible stall under corporate ownership, which could be tested with Unilever segment data and Spate brand search.
- **Comparable survivors:** Bears With Benefits and Vitabiotics gummies (UK pharmacy model, alongside Novomins), Absolute Collagen or The Beauty Chef (prestige ingestible beauty, alongside Vida Glow), Women's Best (women-first, alongside Free Soul), Olly (US gummy mass, alongside SmartyPants).

Recommended Spate category searches

Adding these exports to inputs/category/ would let the next run separate brand success from category growth.

Table 7: Recommended Spate searches. Source: pattern report.

Spate search	Markets	What it would test
"gummy vitamins" / "gummies supplements"	US, UK, AU	Category tailwind behind SmartyPants and Novomins (P2, timing)
"liquid vitamins" / "liquid multivitamin"	US, UK	Whether MaryRuth's grew with or ahead of its format
"marine collagen" / "collagen supplement" / "liquid collagen" / "collagen sachets"	US, UK, AU	Collagen tailwind for Vida Glow, Novomins and Free Soul; format shifts
"greens powder" / "mango greens"	UK, US	Whether Free Soul rode or created the greens wave
"supplements for women" / "women's multivitamin" / "perimenopause supplements"	UK, US	Size and growth of the women's need-state all five target (P6)
"hair growth supplement" / "biotin" / "hair vitamins"	US, UK	The beauty-extension pattern (P7)
"creatine for women" / "magnesium gummies" / "magnesium glycinate"	UK, US	Trend SKUs and the timing of entry
"kids vitamins" / "prenatal vitamins"	US, UK	Life-stage demand behind MaryRuth's and SmartyPants
Brand-name searches for all five brands, side by side	US, UK, AU, DE	Relative brand trajectories; whether TikTok Shop events, retail listings and celebrity launches lifted search; whether SmartyPants stalled after 2020

11. Sources

Every finding comes from the 2026-10-06 pattern report; the brand reports supplied only scorecard scores and milestone dates for charts.

- **reports/patterns/supplement-brands-2026-10-06.md:** Cross-brand pattern report (brand-pattern-finder), run 2026-10-06. The source of every finding in this document.
- **reports/brands/maryruths.md:** MaryRuth's brand strategy report, 2026-10-06. Scorecard and timeline dates.
- **reports/brands/freesoul.md:** Free Soul brand strategy report, 2026-10-06. Scorecard and timeline dates.
- **reports/brands/novomins.md:** Novomins brand strategy report, 2026-10-06. Scorecard and timeline dates.
- **reports/brands/vida-glow.md:** Vida Glow brand strategy report, 2026-10-06. Scorecard and timeline dates.
- **reports/brands/smartypants.md:** SmartyPants brand strategy report, 2026-10-06. Scorecard and timeline dates.

Each brand report lists its own primary sources (for example Forbes, BusinessWire, TikTok Newsroom, Lloyds, The Grocer, NutraIngredients, Unilever and Morgan Stanley releases, retailer listings), all accessed 2026-10-06, mostly through search-result extracts. No Spate export was in inputs/category/ and Revuze was not used. No new research was done for these deliverables.